

out what doesn't work, too. This is probably more valuable, since it can save you the time and expense of finding out on your own.

The inventions of the printing press and, much later, the Internet made it possible for almost anyone to learn from people they never met. Even from dead people. And cheaply, too. A book may cost only \$25, but George Soros says you can make a billion dollars by reading the right book. He's right. People write down their experiences and their insights. Especially important are the memoirs of the old timers who've seen a number of innovations come and go. Read them carefully. They may be able to save you a fortune—and years of trial and error.

As successful people become older, they become more reflective. They wonder why they succeeded. They reminisce. They take guesses. And they are usually quite willing to talk to admiring newcomers. If you're starting out in an industry, find a successful older businessman. Ask for an interview. Just explain that you want to discuss the industry. Ask how he "made it," and what he sees as the important trends. You'll be surprised by how open and ready to talk he is.

In our own experience, a fellow we knew once came to us and said: "I like your business model. I'd like to do something like it. Would you tell me how it works?"

"Sure, we'd love to," we answered. We explained the whole thing, and he set up his own business, modeled on ours. When he had a question, he asked us.

He didn't invent anything. He just applied the lessons we had learned over many years (and at great expense). His new business took off almost immediately and is still going strong. Since he started about 10 years ago, he has made a few innovations of his own, which we are now applying to our business!

DON'T BE A PIONEER

Supposedly, the rugged entrepreneur sticks out his jaw and forces the world into the shape he wants it. He becomes the hero of his own success story.